

Beyond the Answer Machine

Build the context. Question the output. Own the result.

FIRST, TWO WORDS

What we mean by “AI” and “critical thinking.”

AI

Machines doing things that used to need human thinking. And like any thinking, its output is fallible — it has to be *evaluated*, not taken on faith.

CRITICAL THINKING

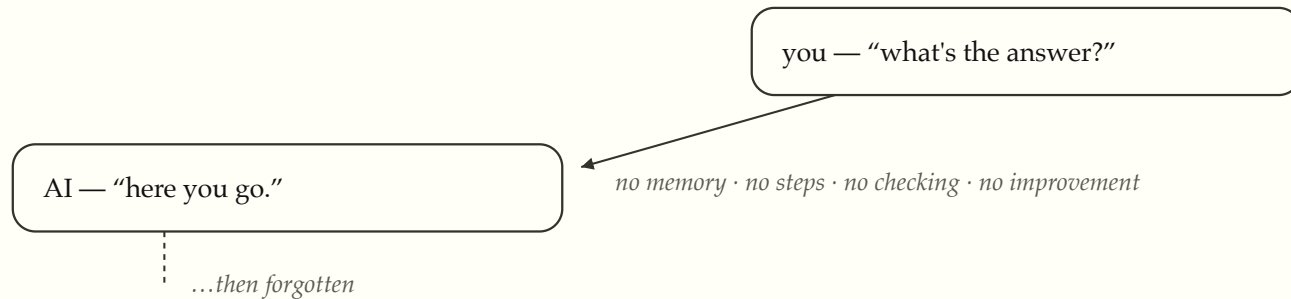
Deciding what to believe on purpose — asking what a claim rests on, what would disprove it, and what it leaves out — instead of accepting it because it sounds right.

AI supplies fluent claims; critical thinking is how you decide which to trust.

THE TRAP

AI as an answer machine.

Most people meet AI through a chatbot: type a question, get an answer. Handy — but it trains you to treat AI as a *vending machine for facts*.

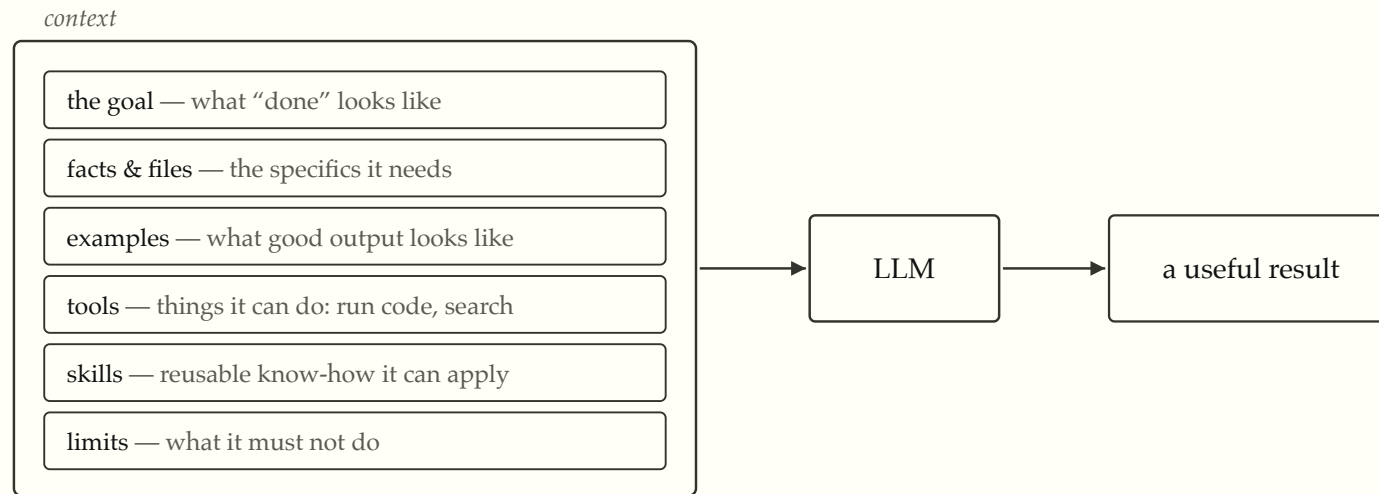


One question in, one answer out — then forgotten.

Everything that view leaves out is the actual job.

Build the system around the model.

It's less about the one clever prompt and more about the *context* you build: the goal, the facts and files that matter, examples, the tools and skills it can use, and the limits.

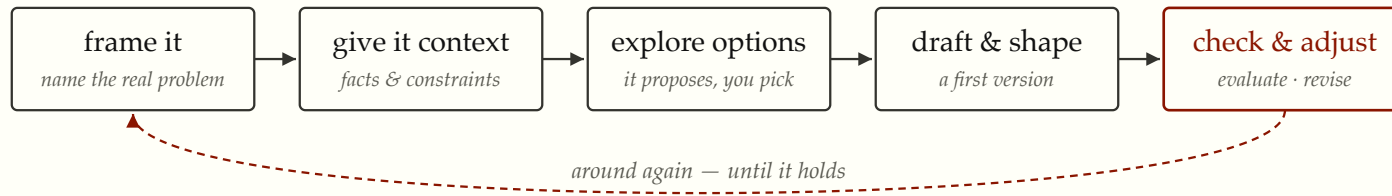


Tools and skills are part of context too — they're what let it act, not just talk.

AI engineering is mostly the craft of building the best context.

Use AI to work a problem.

Don't dump a vague question and take the first reply. Walk the problem through a loop: frame it, ground it, explore, draft — then check, and go around again.



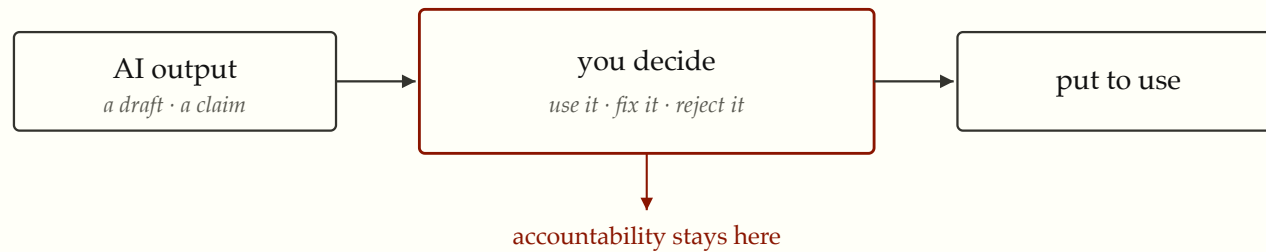
Checking means weighing the claim — not trusting fluent output on sight.

Start with the mess; loop until it's clear.

THE LINE THAT NEVER MOVES

You own what gets used.

A model can draft, suggest, even act — but it can't be *accountable*. A person decides what to use, and carries the consequences. That never transfers to a tool.



The model proposes; a person disposes. However high you climb — prompt, workflow, agent — the judgment still lands on a human.

Automate the work, not the responsibility.

TO WRAP UP

Engineer the system; stay the critic.

Build the setup around the model — **context · steps · checks** — and treat what it returns as a *claim to weigh*, not an answer to accept.

Three things stay yours: **the goal, the standards, and the limits.**

The goal isn't to trust AI more; it's to make trust earned.